

McDonald's L&D Strategy

1. Introduction, Purpose & Business Alignment

McDonald's learning and development (L&D) strategy is designed to build its people to ensure operational excellence at global scale. With over 43,000 restaurants and over two million employees, supervision alone cannot drive consistency. This is where L&D comes in, helping create a structured capability system.

- Protects and delivers QSC&V (Quality, Service, Cleanliness & Value)
- Building an internal leadership pipeline
- Enables global consistency
- Supports long-term talent sustainability

Over **70%** of the senior roles have been filled internally which shows that development can be a strategic lever rather than just a support function aligning and supporting with the business goals.

2. Core capabilities: the best model and values

McDonald's five values: Serve, Inclusion, Integrity, Community, and Family aren't just terms projected to the outside world, they are embodied within the employees themselves. They are assessed as behavioral competencies in performance reviews and are expected from everyone in the organization. They also use the "BEST" competency framework:

- **Building blocks** → behavioral standards and company values.
- **Execution** → operational discipline, consistent delivery of QSC&V
- **Strategy** → long-term thinking, adaptation and change capability
- **Talent** → coaching and mentoring, building diverse leadership pipelines

3. Learning architecture: 70:20:10

Their learning architecture clearly depicts the 70:20:10 framework. 70% of the job learning is delivered through station-based training and real-time performance practice which is accompanied by the 20% coaching and feedback seen through their Crew Trainer model and the structured four-step coaching process: Watch & Learn, Practice with Help, Perform Alone, Feedback & Sign-off. Then the last 10% for formal learning is provided to employees through Fred@McD digital platforms and Hamburger University programs. Fred@McD is the digital performance support and training platform for employees that provides real-time access to operational procedures, training videos and manuals.

4. Hamburger university: formal learning at scale

The Hamburger university (HU) was founded in 1961 and is serving as McDonald's global corporate university.

The university displays different key features:

- 10 global campuses
- 28 languages
- 100,000+ managers trained annually
- 360,000+ graduates historically

The University also uses simulations-based learning which includes live restaurant management scenarios, profit and loss analysis and operational diagnostics. Moreover, HU owns academic

recognition from the American Council on Education (ACE). This distinction is considered unique within the quick-service restaurant sector.

To sum up, Hamburger University leads to the reinforcement of McDonald's leadership capability while institutionalizing operational standards.

5. Career and talent integration: the closed-loop system

McDonald's talent system operates as a closed loop but L&D serves as an important aspect of employee growth and performance. Through the continuous 4C model: Commit, Connect, Conclude, Career, 360 feedback is given and received and individual development plans (SMART goals) are created for individual employees. High performers are identified and developed even further to then set up succession plans using the 9-box model (performance vs. potential). Based on performance and succession evaluation, promotion is encouraged internally. 70%+ of executive roles are filled internally after completing leadership programs at Hamburger University. Learning is embedded across performance reviews, succession planning, and promotion decisions.

6. ACADEMIES Framework

Utilizing the ACADEMIES Framework McDonald's reflects a mature, business-driven learning organization consistent with the McKinsey's ACADEMIES model.

- Clear alignment between learning and business objectives (QSC&V and leadership continuity)
- Structured capability assessment through the BEST framework and 9-box succession planning
- Integration of performance management, promotion, and development in a closed-loop system

While McDonald's L&D system is highly standardized and scalable, there is limited evidence of individualized, self-directed learning pathways or adaptive digital personalization, which the ACADEMIES framework highlights as a characteristic of more mature learning organizations.

7. Conclusion

The size of McDonald's L&D strategy is not the only reason it stands out, it is due to its systematic integration. Each element from the BEST competency model as well as the 70:20:10 leaning approach, Hamburger university and the talent pipeline are all connected to one main goal: reaching robust operational performance while training leaders from inside the company.

This investment is therefore supported by the results. The company shows strong promotion outcomes, large tuition support as well as clear tracking of internal career growth. All of this with numerous senior leaders starting in entry-level restaurant roles.

Rather than treating training as an isolated function, McDonald's has built a performance-driven learning ecosystem that links capability development directly to business results. For HR and business leaders, this poster highlights that when Learning and Development is managed as a strategic system instead of simple training cost, it can improve retention, leadership continuity, performance and long-term business success.

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